described in the *Indo-Pacific Strategy Report* is not merely a checklist of to-do items, but is an approach leading to the ability to act in a holistic fashion throughout Asia's littorals. The Allied Powers in World War II would never have accepted losing the eastern Mediterranean while keeping open the western half, nor should the Pentagon disassociate the South and East China Seas. That objective requires a sufficient forward-based force able to respond to multiple Chinese offensives at the same time, while ensuring credible defense of both allies and strategic nodes such as Taiwan and the Malacca Strait. Though potentially politically risky for Asian nations, given their economic dependence on China, the Pentagon should attempt to coordinate regular peacetime freedom of navigation operations with willing allies and partners throughout the region, while wartime planning should prepare for keeping the entire region a zone of maneuver and control by allied forces.

Second, intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) activities should be strengthened to provide a holistic risk assessment of the Asiatic Mediterranean for both peacetime preparedness and wartime operations. The United States needs robust, survivable ISR coverage of the Asiatic Mediterranean, especially its choke points, and the ISR capabilities of allies and partners should be developed with US help.

Third, the Department of Defense should deepen discussions with both allies and partners on how it can cooperate specifically to help maintain stability, corresponding to the goal of a "networked" region in the *Indo-Pacific Strategy Report*. "Gray zone" incidents short of clear aggression, which often include paramilitary forces, have been increasing between China and its neighbors in recent years, and effective regional responses should be explored that can scale up during times of open conflict. This may include formalizing joint patrols, agreements over nonlethal support, greater sharing of intelligence, and the like. In addition, working with more capable partners like Japan, the US military should consider how to cooperate more effectively on both defensive and offensive cyber operations in the region.

Making promises to try to maintain stability in the Indo-Pacific should not be taken lightly. As Walter Lippmann admonished in *U.S.*